

Hulu Plus

Similar to Netflix, Hulu Plus costs \$7.99 per month and has adverts. This too is limited to the United States so you'll need a VPN to get in. All of the streaming services happen to have a few exclusive TV shows that only air on their service which is essential in maintaining customer base.

Type: Subscription; VPN:Needed

Amazon Prime

For \$99 a year you get access to Amazon's extensive library as well as their music service and quick delivery in the US. Last we checked, Amazon was about to run Prime Air trials in Mumbai and Bangalore. Not everything that is available on Amazon is added to the Prime subscription, some of the newer stuff has to be purchased and the rates are as low as \$2-\$3 for HD content.

Type: Subscription; **VPN:** Needed

iTunes

Apple's service comes with the option of renting as well as purchasing movies. Some content might be restricted to US accounts only but that isn't a difficult thing to circumvent. Since it is a service by Apple you don't need to jump through hoops to get the content onto your iPhone/iPod/iPad. Moreover, you have the option of downloading your content for consumption later. What's better is that you have access to high quality Indian content.

Type: Rental/Purchase; VPN: Optional

Google Play

Google's service follows the same model as iTunes, rental service starts off at as low as ₹25 per movie and purchasing the same would cost anywhere between ₹100-₹500 depending if the content is regional or foreign and if the movie is new or old. TV shows aren't available in India but that's where a VPN can help you out.

Type: Rental/Purchase; VPN: Optional

Regional

Just because you want to watch the latest season of House of Cards shouldn't mean that your mom should have to miss out on her favourite TV soaps. Indian media houses are slowly waking up and putting up content online. Almost every major show has a monetised YouTube video available almost instantly so YouTube does cover almost everything but here are



Online streaming networks are hammering the death knell on traditional TV viewing

a few sites that let you view your shows if YouTube doesn't deliver.

When it comes to regional content there are services like BIGFlix, ErosNow, BoxTv and Spuul which stream movies from the Indian subcontinent. It doesn't matter whether the content is from Bollywood, Kollywood, Tollywood or Bhojpuri cinema, these websites are likely to host content from all of them. Moreover, everyone of them has a subscription service which starts at as low as ₹249 a month and you can watch movies on your mobile device through apps.

No article on regional content could be complete without the mention of Prasar Bharti. Yes, the Indian national broadcaster has its own website which has live news feed. Every news channel has its own Live feed on their respective website as well as on YouTube so you are never going to not find their content online.

Exceptional

Torrents are legal and they are a great medium for content distribution. So much that some of the biggest services in the business also use BitTorrent somewhere in the backbone of their CDN. Indie Artists often release their tracks on torrents since it involves no payment to any hosting service or big studio backing to make themselves heard. And the same goes for movies and indie TV shows; huge events like SXSW release public domain tracks for all bands on their website. Here are some ways to stream torrents:

PopCorn Time

PopCorn time is a unique implementation of the torrent service where the downloaded files aren't stored on your computer. The torrent sources are illegal at the moment and we don't see that changing anytime soon. But the concept is great and open source, but through PopCorn Time you can play anything and the files are deleted from your PC after the content stops streaming. We're hoping that the big streaming players would implement this software, since PopCorn Time have opened up their source code.

Media Center Master

Media Center Master is the complete package when it comes to a media organisation software. You just need to point it to your media folder and the software goes through it gathering metadata and helps you organise/rename content and even download missing videos. Think you have all the music videos of your favourite indie band? This software might surprise you. The options in this tool are vast and it will take you some time to configure it all but post setup it will automate everything.

For everything else

Well, you can cancel your DTH connection and still get all the content that you want but not everything is available at the moment. So for everything else you can go check <http://www.freetv.com> and they'll direct you to the legal stream. Time to get on with the times, yes? Stream on! 